Week 18

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 5 · LESSON 2

Resurrection

BIG IDEA

Without the resurrection, Christianity falls apart, and the resurrection can be examined as a real historical event. The evidence for it outweighs every rival explanation, so the bigger question for students is what changes if they're convinced.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. In 1 Corinthians 15, Paul makes the resurrection the thread everything hangs on; many church kids know Jesus rose but have never heard there's historical evidence for it.
2. Mainline history agrees Jesus lived, was crucified by the Romans and buried; Paul names witnesses, the twelve and more than 500 people, almost inviting readers to go ask them.
3. The intro experience looks at events before students' lifetimes, like the Roman Empire or the Civil War, so they can treat the resurrection as history too.
4. For a storyteller, find a history teacher or buff who tells history well; the Gospels are history told as a story that builds to Jesus' death and resurrection.
5. No historical event is proven beyond all doubt; the best evidence decides. Beyond the Bible, Jewish and Roman historians and early Christian writings report the resurrection.
6. Rival theories (Jesus only fainted, ended in a shallow grave, or was swapped for another body) all have less evidence. Students will meet the "myth" claim in college.

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO 1 Corinthians 15

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. If the resurrection is the thread everything hangs on, how does that shape the way I live this week?
2. How well could I explain the historical evidence for the resurrection to a skeptical student?
3. Which student might be holding back, and how can I learn what's really in the way?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. What would be lost from Christianity if Jesus had stayed in the grave?
2. How do we know about events like the Roman Empire, and how does the evidence for the resurrection compare?
3. Which other explanation for the empty tomb have you heard, and how does it hold up against the evidence?
4. Where do you land on whether the resurrection happened, and what questions are still in the way?
5. If the resurrection is true, what might need to change in how you live or talk about Jesus?

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The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

A conversation with students

0:05 Several years ago I was talking to a group of students, and I was explaining to them basically what's in 1 Corinthians 15. I was explaining the fact that without the resurrection, Christianity would cease to exist. It was once described to me that it's almost as if the resurrection were a tiny little thread connected to the fate of the world, and if we were to cut that thread, everything would fall apart. I was explaining this to my students, and the looks on their faces were priceless. You could tell that they didn't know anything I was explaining to them. It was all new news to them. They knew the resurrection. They were good Christian kids. They knew and believed that Jesus had resurrected, and they knew that it had something to do — or maybe everything to do — with their salvation.

0:54 But they hadn't realized: what if Jesus hadn't resurrected? What if he had just stayed in the grave? We always talked about how Jesus was crucified for our sins, but he was also resurrected. So there's that second piece in the equation that's really super important. Then I said to them, did you know that there's historical evidence behind the resurrection? Well, that was a whole other look on their faces that I can't even describe. It was fascinating, but it was so encouraging to me, because I knew that there was something to be taught here, and that there was something these students were going to gain from what I was telling them.

Jesus as a historical figure

1:36 It's likely that you're going to get some of those same looks as you start to talk with some of your students about this, because so many students know that Jesus existed. I mean, let's face it — it's not a new thing that Jesus was a historical figure. You're going to get a few people on the fringe who believe otherwise, but all mainline history says Jesus existed. He was crucified by the Romans. He was buried in a tomb. And what? It's reported that he rose three days after. Interesting.

2:11 But there's history behind it, which is why we focus on Paul's comments in 1 Corinthians 15, to help students start to see the importance of the resurrection before we dive into the historical reliability of the resurrection. We want them to really get the whole picture of it, along with the fact that even in chapter 15 Paul gives a little bit of that historical account. Jesus appeared to people. He appeared to the twelve, and he appeared to more than 500 people. The way Paul says this is almost as if he's saying, "Hey, they're alive. Go check it out. Go ask them. If you don't believe me, it's no big deal."

2:50 So as your students are going through their intro experience, we want them to start to think about a historically documented and verified event that happened before their lifetime. We want them to go into history, and a good place to do this is really in their history books. How

much of the Roman Empire do we know about? How much of Alexander the Great do we know about? How much of the Civil War do we know about? How much of the historical events that happened long before us do we actually have information on?

3:22 We want them to start to see it, because as much as we look at Scripture — because it is the Word of God, and it's wholly inspired, and it's awesome — we can also take a step back and say, well, what does this say from a historical perspective? What does it say about Jesus as a historical person? What does it say about the resurrection as a historical event? We want students to start thinking of the resurrection, just for a moment, as a historical event. That's what this exercise is really designed to do: to connect them to the idea that the resurrection is actually history.

Finding a storyteller

4:02 Okay, so for your storyteller, I would recommend going to a local college or a local Christian high school and finding somebody who is a history professor or a history buff, or somebody who really knows not just history, but how to tell history well. Find someone who knows how to tell the story of history. I say that because that's really what the Gospels are doing. The Gospels are the account of Jesus. We know this, but it's a story that's describing history.

4:32 So if you can get someone who can do the same thing with another piece of history, you'll be able to help students start to make that connection and start to see the Gospels as this historical narrative that wells up and culminates with the death and resurrection of Christ. It's a very cool picture. If you do it right, you can paint it really, really well.

Answering the myth

4:53 We want to make sure of something. It's not a huge issue among students, but it is out there, and they will run into it when they get to college: the claim that the resurrection was just a myth. So, yeah, okay, Jesus died, and it's a myth that the church made up that he resurrected. It's important that we help students see that that's not historically accurate. We'll get into more of why that is as we move forward over the next couple of weeks, but it's important to help students see that this is something they're going to hear as they go into college and beyond.

5:26 Okay, so students are going to be able to see at the end of this that the resurrection is actually historical. Now, does that mean that we can say this is a for-sure thing and that it's absolute? Well, I would say, yeah, of course it is, but that's a bit different. Can we prove that Jesus resurrected? Well, not beyond a shadow of a doubt, of course not. But we can't do that with anything in history, right? We can't prove too many things in history beyond a shadow of a doubt, because we weren't there.

5:55 But the way history is done — and what you'll see even from the storyteller, the historian — is that the one with the best evidence is the one who gets to say what happened. So the question is: do we have the best possible evidence for the resurrection? There are a couple of things that I want to make sure you can explore more deeply. You can get into a little bit more. You can present it to your students. You can get into discussions about this within your small

group time. If your students want to go a little bit deeper, there are some really cool things you can do.

The resurrection as history

6:26 So, the resurrection as history. Now, when we think of history, most people think of, well, it's the Bible, right? So the number one place we all look is the Bible. The Bible could be viewed as a history book. That's the Word of God. We don't want to make it a textbook, but there's history in it. Okay, that's great. So there's some evidence there. We have one piece of evidence in the Bible. But what do people say? Well, that's the Bible, and you can't believe everything the Bible says. We'll get into that later. Actually, we can — but we'll get into that later.

6:58 But what else, then? Are there other things? What about outside of the Bible? Are there things outside of the Bible that give us clues that Jesus resurrected? There are. There are Jewish historians. There are Roman historians who recorded events about the resurrection — that at least the disciples of the early years thought that Jesus resurrected, and who recorded that they were reporting that Jesus resurrected. So that's important. There are early Christian writings like the Didache, and letters from a church father named Clement, that talk about the resurrection. These aren't in the Bible. They're good Christian writings, the stuff that we still use and study in the world of scholarship to figure out what's going on historically. But that's awesome. And you've got even now skeptics, people who aren't Christians, saying that Jesus was reported as resurrected.

8:27 Now, this kind of raises the question. All right — if all of these areas say that Jesus resurrected, or at least give us clues to know that people believed that he did, that's pretty good. Well, maybe there are other explanations. Maybe there are other things going on. Every other explanation given has to provide more evidence, better evidence, than the hypothesis, if you will, that he resurrected. And when you do that, without going into all the details, they all fall short. There's the one that says he just sort of fainted, that he wasn't really dead, so therefore he didn't have to worry about it. There are ones that say he wasn't actually buried in the tomb, that he was buried in a shallow grave and some birds and wild dogs ended up eating his body.

9:20 There are some people who say they just grabbed a body and pretended it was Jesus, and it really wasn't. There are all kinds of different theories, none of which have the same amount of evidence as the resurrection. So this is exactly why we wanted to connect it with history. When we look at other historical events and how much evidence there is for those, we have just as much or more for the resurrection as for pretty much most other historical events, especially historical events that happened around the same time. And we'll see that when we talk about Scripture specifically. So help your students see that this was a historical event, and that there's evidence for it as a historical event.

Small group time

10:02 But just like last week, I would do the same thing that you did last week. I'd go into your small groups and I would ask them, number one: are you convinced that it's at least possible that the

evidence points to Jesus resurrecting? And number two: if you are convinced, what does that mean? We talked in the very beginning about the importance of the resurrection, right? If the resurrection is out there, all of Christianity falls down. So if you're convinced of the resurrection, what does that now mean for your life? What needs to change? What needs to be furthered? How does your spiritual walk need to go even further than maybe it is now? What does that mean for you? What does that mean for how you talk to other people about the resurrection and Jesus and who he is, and what the crucifixion and resurrection actually mean, and what salvation is all about?

10:53 Ask students not just whether they believe this stuff, but have them dig into, okay, now what? What does all this mean? What do I do with all this information? And if they're not convinced, and they're still kind of going, "I'm not sure," that's okay. But now is the time when you can start digging a little bit into, okay, well, what questions do you continue to have? What roadblocks are there that I can help knock down? What do I need to do to help bring you along a little bit, or better, to help you understand these things a little bit more deeply? Is it a misunderstanding? Is it that I'm just not getting something? Or is it something bigger?

11:30 Now is the time that you might start to see some roadblocks in some students' lives, some walls they might put up. They might want to believe this stuff. They might really love the idea, but they might still hold back. And as you walk alongside these students, you're going to need to start figuring out why that is and what's going on. That's why we talked at the very beginning about the importance of building relationships, because now it's going to start to really matter. If it hasn't mattered before, now it's really going to get there, because there are going to be some major changes going on in your students' lives.